SECOND WATCH: FLEET COMMANDER'S QUICK-START

Everything you need to run a first session in about two hours: what to prepare, a ten-minute rules talk, and a ready-to-run first mission set after a great battle. The full rules are in Second Watch: Tabletop Rules.

BEFORE THE SESSION

- **Pick the profile and power level.** For a first game: Fleet profile, Line level (800 FC), 2–3 captains.
- **Ships.** Each captain builds a ship in Drydock under Build rules → Line, or starts from the freighter or courier template. In Launch → Second Watch, they pick a command style and print the record sheet (two pages).
- **Print for the table:** one record sheet per ship, one campaign log per ship, and one set of opponent cards. Blank and sample copies are in the Library.
- **Bring:** three six-sided dice per player, pencils, and a ruler in inches if a fight breaks out. Tokens or 50 mm prints work as miniatures.
- **Optional:** open Launch → Second Watch → Run a mission on a laptop or tablet in the middle of the table. It rolls scenes in the open and checks each ship against the orders.

THE TEN-MINUTE RULES TALK

Read or paraphrase this to the table:

1. **You are captains.** Your crew are skilled professionals; you decide what they attempt. I am the Fleet Commander: I give the orders and play everyone else.
2. **One roll.** Roll two dice and add the roll bonus from your sheet for the department doing the work. Meet the target: 6 is routine, 8 standard, 10 hard, 12 heroic. Your bonus never goes above +4.
3. **Your ship matters.** A facility that fits the job gives advantage (roll three dice, keep the best two). A missing system gives disadvantage (keep the worst two).
4. **How well it went.** Beat the target by 3: success, and we gain Momentum to spend later. Miss by 1 or 2: it still works, but at a cost I pick. Miss by more: it fails and the story moves on.
5. **Your ship's traits.** The traits on your sheet come from your design. Use one when it fits and roll with advantage. Once a mission I may turn one against you, and you gain Resolve for it.
6. **Resolve.** Each captain has 3 Resolve per mission. Spend one to reroll, or to add +1 after seeing the dice.

7. **Fights.** If talking fails, we put ships on the table and use the Skirmish rules on page 1 of your sheet.

FIRST MISSION: THE SALVAGE LINE

Setting. One week after the Battle of Halcyon Gate. An unknown alien fleet, which the news feeds now call the Hollow Fleet, came through the gate, destroyed most of the task force sent against it, and vanished. Your fleet is rebuilding fast, and the debris field is still full of wreckage, survivors' logs, and alien technology that must not fall into the wrong hands.

Read aloud (the Fleet Commander's orders):

> Captains, the Halcyon Gate debris field is now a restricted zone. Your task force will recover the flight recorders from three of our lost ships, search for survivors in sealed compartments, and collect or destroy any alien material you find. Corporate salvage crews and independent haulers have already been seen at the edge of the field. You are authorized to warn them off. You are not authorized to start a war over scrap. Command out.

Requirements. Sensors and shuttles or small craft. **Helpful:** fabrication shops, damage control center, detention cells.

SCENE 1: INTO THE FIELD (SCIENCE 8)

The wreckage is dense and some of it is still powered. Each captain chooses a sector. Success: the ship finds a flight recorder and a safe approach. Failure: the ship drifts into a live power conduit and marks 2 Hull boxes, but finds the recorder anyway.

SCENE 2: SEALED COMPARTMENT (ENGINEERING 10, OR OPERATIONS 9 WITH A SHUTTLE)

A hull section has a sealed compartment with faint life signs. Cutting in risks breaching it. Success: four survivors recovered. Failure: the compartment holds, but the rescue takes the rest of the day (lose 1 Supply). On Success, plus, one survivor saw something about the alien ships that fleet intelligence will want.

SCENE 3: ALIEN MATERIAL (SCIENCE 9, THEN A CAPTAIN'S CHOICE)

One ship finds an intact piece of alien technology, still faintly active. Roll to contain it safely. Then the captain decides: destroy it now, or bring it home for study. Bringing it home earns +1 Reputation, but the Fleet Commander secretly notes it: it comes back in a later mission.

SCENE 4: THE SALVAGERS (COMMAND 9 OR DIPLOMACY 9)

A corporate salvage ship and two independent haulers are cutting up a hull. They wave a salvage writ and insist it is legal. Success: they leave peacefully, or agree to hand over anything fleet command needs. Failure: the largest hauler opens fire. Run a short Skirmish with the Raider opponent card (one per two player ships), ending when the raiders lose half their Hull.

Twist (Fleet Commander only). One of the flight recorders shows a ship that was ordered away from the battle before it started. Who gave that order is a campaign hook, not something to resolve tonight.

Debrief. At least three scenes succeeded: 160 FC and 2 Reputation per ship, and 1 Renown per captain. Two: 80 FC, no Reputation. Fewer: no pay; the Fleet Commander explains what fleet command thinks of the task force. Each ship marks one completed mission on its campaign log.

Make it your own. The structure works in any setting: a disaster at a jump point, a battle at a station, a convoy lost in a nebula. Swap in your own enemy, your own salvagers, and your own secret in the wreckage.

AFTER THE SESSION

- Fill in the campaign logs: FC, Reputation, Renown, damage carried, and the twist.
- Repairs cost 5 FC per Hull box and 20 FC per systems box. Unrepaired damage carries over.
- Ask the table which thread they want to pull next: the missing ship from the flight recorder, the alien material, or the salvagers. That is your second mission.
- Note what felt too easy or too hard, and share it with the person running the playtest.